

This is an all out war and the side of the citizen and consumer is woefully under-armed. But all hope is not lost. Not yet.

There Is This Machine That Spies

In India the idea of mass surveillance isn't discussed very often. So it isn't likely to have a fiery conversation about CMS, NATGRID or NETRA with anyone since there's a great chance that they wouldn't know what any of these acronyms mean. Unfortunately that's exactly what they want people to do – not talk about it. So let us begin our journey of self-defence with a little briefing on what's out there in our own country.

Using the power of the Indian Telegraph Act of 1885 the Indian government successfully deployed its version of PRISM within India. By taking advantage of the broad and unfettered boundaries of this law the Indian government was able to establish and build the systems necessary to conduct mass digital surveillance without any parliamentary approval. The unholy trinity that is the Central Monitoring System (CMS), the National Intelligence Grid (NATGRID) and Network



NETRA also includes unmanned UAV drones for enhanced monitoring.

Traffic Analysis (NETRA) programs went live in 2014 and are projected to grow over time. The three different systems work in unison to track, record, monitor, analyse, intercept, data mine and store the communications of Indian citizens.

By using indigenously produced technologies from scientists at the Indian Institute of Sciences and the Center for Artificial Intelligence and Robotics – a



Spies, the secret service kind or even your local peeping tom variety are always lurking

Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) unit, we now live in a country where citizens lack basic privacy in their communications. Nearly eleven government agencies have access to this data the biggest of which being the Indian spy agency – the Research and Analysis Wing or RAW and India's domestic intelligence agency – the Intelligence Bureau.

Conceived as a defensive system in the wake of the 26/11 Mumbai terrorist attacks this system was intended to help security agencies prevent future tragedies. Since India doesn't have a legal history regarding privacy laws there has been little wide scale public outcry. The activist agencies that have worked to stop and criticise these measures have met with little public support. And now perhaps it is too late.

The abilities of this system include the means to access the entire Indian telecommunications network and listen in and store calls made on mobiles, landlines satellites and even the internet (VoIP). It also extends towards reading private emails and messages all the while maintaining a real-time location monitoring of the sources. The system is also designed to monitor content on major social media websites and even track a user's Google history. The program uses predictive algorithms, pattern recogni-

tion and real time voice analyses to seek out the content of its target subjects. All of this without a single court order being necessary or a vote being passed to allow this intrusion. These systems were started in the name of national security. Now that you know about their existence do you feel any safer?

Anonymizing Yourself

There is a common argument offered in defence of government run surveillance activities – that government agencies are only interested in terrorists and dangerous individuals. Normal law abiding citizens have nothing to fear – anyway if you haven't done anything illegal then you have no reason to be worried. But that isn't the point – as citizens and individuals we are entitled to our privacy. And even if we can somehow get the laws to change who is going to tell the criminals who use technology against to follow the rules? The only sane thing to do is to protect yourself on your own since, in this instance, both the authorities and criminals are pretty much against the interest of your privacy.

Let's not forget that what we know is just about the activities of the government. The activities of criminal agents and others isn't even available for review and criticism – it can range from social engineered hacks to malicious spyware on your computer or mobile device. The idea of being yourself online and even on your cell phone can now seem like a risk. Perhaps it would be easier in the old days where anonymity online was a given.

There are a few simple and a few complicated ways of protecting yourself against the intrusion of others. Amongst